

Assessing the Quality of Review Corpus: A Key to Rigorous Systematic Literature Review

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Systematic literature reviews (SLRs) have become an increasingly important tool in evidence-based practice, as they provide a comprehensive and transparent synthesis of the available research on a given topic (Boren & Moxley, 2015; Perera, 2020). SLRs play a pivotal role in informing decision-making across diverse domains, including healthcare, social sciences and business. In a time when information is abundant, the importance of synthesizing knowledge through SLRs has never been greater. However, the methodological robustness, particularly the quality assessment of included studies, needs further discussion. This is because the quality assessment determines the usefulness and trustworthiness of an SLR (Perera, 2020). Thus, this editorial argues that a robust and transparent quality assessment process is paramount to ensure the reliability and impact of SLRs. It will ultimately contribute to a more solid foundation for future research and practice.

A detailed article on writing impactful reviews has been published in our journal by Varsha et al. (2024); therefore, our focus will remain on the quality assessment aspect. Nonetheless, to build up the background, we will briefly discuss the fundamentals of conducting an SLR before focusing on the quality assessment of the selected corpus for a robust study.

Why SLRs Matter

SLR is a rigorous and transparent method for synthesizing and integrating existing research (Fan et al., 2022), which helps identify research gaps and delineate future research trajectories (Paul & Criado, 2020; Paul & Menzies, 2023). Additionally, it establishes a foundation for new research activities (Paul & Barari, 2022) and outlines the structure and objectives of the manuscript. It reviews, assesses and analyses all existing research related to a specific question, topic or area of interest (Kitchenham et al., 2009). Another key role that SLRs play is that they minimize the bias through pre-defined search methods, inclusion/exclusion search criteria and quality evaluation (Torraco, 2005). Its transparent methodology makes it easier to examine and replicate the study's outputs, providing scholars and practitioners with reliable evidence (Varsha et al., 2024). SLRs also help in theory development, supporting or contradicting pre-existing theoretical frameworks (Paul & Menzies, 2023). Therefore, SLRs are a crucial element of any research project.

Conducting an SLR: The 'How'

As mentioned earlier, a brief overview of the foundational step of SLR is discussed hereafter, followed by a deep dive into the quality assessment step.

Define the Research Question/Objective (RQ/Os)

The RQs provides a framework for finding and evaluating relevant studies, serving as the structural underpinning of SLRs. According to Berdanier and Lenart (2020), a well-crafted question plays an important role in preserving the SLRs' focus and relevance. After defining the RQs, it is important to determine the SLRs' scope. The scope includes setting proper limits, defining the target population and specifying contextual criteria. According to Webster and Watson (2002), a clear scope keeps the SLR on track with RQs/Os and prevents irrelevant content from being included in the SLR.

Develop a Search Strategy

Once the RQs and scope are defined, the next step is to develop a search strategy. In this step, the relevant keywords and concepts are determined that are closely associated with the RQs. Before accessing the database, authors might use Google Scholar to find preliminary keywords and relevant phrases for additional research (Kumar et al., 2025). These are the keywords that the database search looks for and the basis for the search queries. To get valid and relevant literature, it is necessary to select the appropriate databases and sources (like Scopus or WoS). Academic databases, specific publications and conference proceedings are examples of commonly used sources (Alagoz et al., 2018). According to Webster and Watson (2002), adding Boolean operators (AND, OR, NOT) in search strings can improve results by narrowing the search.

Conduct the Search

Once the search strategy has been completed, the search keywords should be entered into the appropriate databases and the results retrieved. EndNote and other programmes can be quite useful for tracking and organizing all of your search results. It is important to record the steps and track the search process, such as the databases searched, the phrases used and the number of results found (Aromataris & Riitano, 2014) (the process can be done again). The next step is to eliminate any duplicate articles and sort through the articles that are relevant.

Screen and Select Studies

The screening and selection of studies are key parts of the SLR. Defining inclusion and exclusion criteria is crucial for deciding which studies to consider for the SLR. According to Meline (2006), inclusion criteria may focus on the study's relevance to the RQ/Os, while exclusion criteria may consider factors like publication year or geographical location. The process begins with the reading and evaluation of titles and abstracts to identify relevant studies, followed by the retrieval of full texts and a final eligibility assessment according to established criteria.

Assesses Study Quality

SLRs attempt to include credible studies to ensure the findings are accurate. When evaluating the quality of a study, factors such as the reliability of the outcome measurements, the study's design and potential

sources of bias are considered. It is appropriate to record the approach used to grade the quality explicitly, to see how the studies were rated and how much weight was given to each study's results.

Extract Data

Data extraction is the process of getting useful data from studies that have passed a quality assessment check. To avoid errors that could jeopardize the synthesis, ensure that the extracted data are correct and complete. This helps to focus on only those articles that are most relevant to the RQs to make sure that important studies or data points are collected and evaluated correctly.

Synthesize the Evidence

The synthesis of evidence is the essence of a literature review, in which all gathered data are examined for patterns, themes and inter-relationships. This step entails an in-depth review of the findings from all selected research and the development of conclusions based on the gathered evidence. Synthesizing evidence entails not just summarizing studies but also analysing findings in the context of existing literature to enhance the understanding of the subject matter. The focus is on addressing the topic by integrating findings from various studies, emphasizing areas of agreement, disagreement and gaps in understanding.

Write the Review

Writing the review is the final step in the literature review process. A well-organized review is essential for making the information clear and simple to interpret. Booth (2021) recommends that the review be divided into various sections, such as introduction, methodology, results, discussion and conclusion.

Using tables and figures to present the most relevant studies is an effective method of ensuring that the information is easily understandable. A good conclusion, like a good synthesis, will summarize the key themes and offer suggestions for further research.

Hence, SLRs have an established process, which if done thoroughly results into highly relevant studies for future research directions. Of all the steps, the assessment of the quality of the study corpus can be the difference between acceptance and rejection of the study. Hence, the remainder of the editorial will discuss the quality assessment criteria of SLR studies.

Nuances of Quality Assessment

Kumar et al. (2025) highlighted that robust quality assessment minimizes bias and ensures the inclusion of studies with strong methodological foundations. A critical evaluation of the methodologies used in the studies reveals potential predispositions that the authors may have and assesses the confidence level in the findings. Thus, an effective quality assessment process improves the credibility and reliability of findings in SLR. Therefore, the assessment criteria should be transparent.

Moreover, quality assessment is not just a checklist; it should use criteria that have been thoroughly evaluated and are appropriate for the research. It is usually recommended to document the judgement

criteria, explain why decisions are made and demonstrate how the quality ratings were applied. While it is believed to be time-consuming, the benefits, such as making review process more rigorous and fair, go beyond these negative aspects.

Steps in Quality Assessment

The quality assessment process for an SLR consists of key components (Boren & Moxley, 2015). First is developing a set of quality standards appropriate for the study designs and topics under consideration. These criteria include the suitability of the study design, the reliability and validity of the outcome measurements, the thoroughness of the reporting and the risk of bias or confounding. Subsequently, these quality standards are applied on each study selected for the SLR. The results of the quality assessment are compiled to assist in the interpretation and presentation of the review's outcomes. The details of each step of the quality assessment is discussed hereafter.

Define Quality Criteria

It is essential to define the criteria for evaluating the quality of the studies included in the review (Ain et al., 2019). The potential for bias and the quality of the research should be the main emphasis of these criteria. Among the frequent issues with study designs are inaccurate measurements, poor subject selection and improper statistical analysis. Another potential issue that may come up during a topic review is the use of outcome measures that are not appropriate for addressing the research question. Create a grading scheme that will give each study a score or quality rankings (Ain et al., 2019; Kumar et al., 2025) like 'high', 'medium' or 'low', as determined by these criteria.

Develop a Quality Assessment Tool

Creating a checklist or questionnaire based on the quality requirements that have been defined is crucial. Use assessment tools that have been reviewed and are appropriate for the types of studies being investigated (Ain et al., 2019). Like empirical studies, a pilot study to ensure the tool's accuracy and consistency across the chosen studies is often done and advised. This will demonstrate how simple and reliable the tool is to use.

Conduct the Assessment

Use the quality assessment tool to rate each study in the review (Ain et al., 2019). Check the quality of the papers to make sure they are relevant for the SLR (Kumar et al., 2025). Write out the assessment criteria, the rationale for the decisions and how the quality ratings contributed to the evidence. Get more than one expert to review to increase reliability. The Cohen's kappa statistic can be used to determine the degree of agreement between two or more experts.

Interpret and Use the Results

Examine the quality scores to identify any potential biases or limitations in the studies included. Investigate whether variations in study quality could help explain differences in results. Consider excluding studies with low quality from the analysis. A study is considered high quality if it scores above 3, medium quality if it scores between 1 and 3, and low quality if it scores below 1 (Kumar et al., 2025). It is also important to acknowledge the limitations of quality assessment, as many primary studies are not well-reported, which can make it challenging to evaluate certain quality criteria.

Working Example of Applying Quality Assessment

We take an example of the study ‘Social Media and the Bottom of the Pyramid: A Systematic Literature Review and Future Research Agenda’ (Kumar et al., 2025) to present how quality assessment works.

The selected study analysed insights from 44 studies and performed keyword co-occurrence and TCCM analysis. Through quality assessment, the most rigorous and relevant research papers were selected for the SLR. It involved evaluating papers based on the methodology, contextual relevance and user-centric insights. The assessment enhanced the credibility and applicability of the findings, as stakeholders sought to leverage the potential of social media at the bottom of the pyramid (BOP). The study found that the United States and India are popular contexts for studying the BOP, and the BOP population uses social media for utilitarian, hedonic and social values. Additionally, it can help the BOP to explore entrepreneurship opportunities, value co-creation and bring innovations.

Selection and Rejection of Articles

To start the selection and rejection of articles, certain generic questions for the quality assessment criteria are provided in Table 1, which can be used in all studies.

Hereafter, we discuss the steps using the study on social media and BOP mentioned earlier.

1. Process

- Apply inclusion and exclusion criteria after the keyword search.
- The paper initially identified 554 articles (Kumar et al., 2025). After removing duplicates and applying selection criteria, 57 articles were selected for quality assessment (Kumar et al., 2025).

Table 1. Example of Quality Assessment Criteria.

Q1	Is the research topic relevant to the subject of the review?
Q2	Is the context of the research clearly defined?
Q3	Does the research clearly describe its methodology?
Q4	Are the data collection methods explained well?
Q5	Is the data analysis approach clearly outlined in the research?

Source: Adapted from Ain et al. (2019).

2. Inclusion and exclusion criteria (IC/EC)

- Each study is screened based on its abstract, introduction, results and conclusions.
- The analysis includes papers written in English.
- Studies must be related to social media and the bottom of the pyramid.
- Studies are excluded if they mention social media or BOP only in passing (in references, tables, etc.).

3. Purpose

- To ensure that the selected studies contain information that addresses the research questions.

4. Criteria

- Each article is ranked against specific QA criteria/questions.
- The following QA criteria were used:
 - o QA1: Do the research topic and findings discuss the use of social media at BOP?
 - o QA2: Is there clarity in the context of the study (use of SM at BOP)?
 - o QA3: Is the research methodology clearly defined?
 - o QA4: Is the procedure for gathering the data adequately described?
 - o QA5: Is the data analysis method explained?

5. Rating

- Each QA criterion is rated as 'high', 'medium' or 'poor'.
- A score of 1 is given if a study entirely satisfies a criterion, 0.5 if it partly fulfils it and 0 if it does not meet the criterion.
- The best possible rating is 5, and the lowest is 0.

6. Classification

- Studies scoring over 3 are considered high quality (Kumar et al., 2025).
- Studies scoring between 1 and 3 are of medium quality.
- Studies scoring less than 1 are low quality (see Table 2).

7. Outcome

- In the example paper (see Kumar et al., 2025), of the 57 articles assessed for QA, 13 articles were removed for not meeting the QA threshold, resulting in 44 final studies (Kumar et al., 2025).

A general template for a quality assessment is provided in Table 2.

Table 2 helps systematically assess and document the quality of each study included in the literature review.

Table 2. Quality Assessment.

Study ID	Topic	Context	Methodology	Data Gathering	Data Analysis	Total Score	Result
QA1	1	1	0.5	1	1	4.5	Selected
QA2	1	1	1	1	1	5	Selected
QA3	0.5	0.5	0	0	1	2	Selected
QA4	1	0	0	0	0	0	Rejected
QA5	0	0	0	0	0	0	Rejected

Note: Study ID (a unique identifier for each study), QA criteria (the scores for each quality assessment question), total score (the sum of the scores for all QA criteria) and quality rating (the overall quality rating based on the total score).

Advanced Quality Assessment Criteria for Future Research

Apart from the above-mentioned quality assessment criteria, some other best practices can be considered to further increase the chances of acceptance. First is to adopt open science practices, wherein the authors make the review protocols publicly available. This not only promotes transparency but also increases the reliability of the study. Second is to further delve into the contextual relevance; instead of just mentioning that the paper is of BOP context (taking from the example above), one may further check different contextual aspects such as gender, ethnicity, language, culture and race. This allows one to explore whether the studies are inclined towards only certain contextual backgrounds or they are varied. Third is that 'Fit for Purpose' should be determined during the assessment; by this we mean that assessment criteria identified should be aligned with the objective of the study. This implies that not all studies will have the same quality assessment criteria; rather it will change to suite the need for the SLR.

Conclusion

To conclude, it is important to note that just including a quality assessment step is not sufficient. A hastily designed assessment may result in questionable outcomes. Hence, one should invest significant time in developing the quality assessment criteria, test its validity and then proceed. This may take multiple iterations, but the rigour increases the chances of acceptance.

As we conclude this editorial, it is necessary to note that one may not necessarily find the same assessment protocol in all SLR studies; hence, nonetheless, all studies are required to transparently describe the choice of the study objective and the study corpus included for the review.

Current Issue

The current issue includes five articles, of which two are review articles and the remaining three are research articles. The first article of the issue by Varda Sardana, Shubham Singhanian and Amiya Kumar Mohapatra offers insights into 'macroeconomics facets of banking' by reviewing 278 articles. Their study adds value to the literature by developing a conceptual framework discussing the multitude of macroeconomic factors that affect the banking operations. The next review study by Meenakshi Ahlawat and Mohit Garg discusses the significant areas in the field of organizational citizenship behaviour. The third study in the issue by Mika Artturi Tonder explores the entrepreneurial culture in a university setting. The study reveals that teaching is a small part of creating an entrepreneurial mindset. Instead, it is the sociopsychological environment that shapes the identity of the students in a university entrepreneurial community. The fourth research article authored by Shahid Latif, Safrul Izani Mohd Salleh, Bilal Ahmad and Faseeha Saif presents a case study of the adoption of ERP in a manufacturing SME to strengthen the management accounting and control. Their study results in a conceptual framework that establishes that 'institutional alignment and capability building interact recursively rather than sequentially'. The final article in the issue by Ritika Jain, Pallavi Srivastava and Anubhav Mishra is one of the initial articles discussing the importance of me-time in the vast literature of work-life balance. This study is particularly important in the context of collectivist societies where personal time is often tied to family.

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